



# How to talk to an employee about a mistake: 16 questions and opening lines, by moment (2026)

Last checked 5 October 2026. Fill in the [BRACKETS] with your own facts.

## Questions about a mistake

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What happened, in your own words?

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What did you notice at the time?

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What would you do differently next time?

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What do you need in order to put it right?

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What help do you want from me?

## Three ways to open

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I want to talk about what happened in [MEETING OR EMAIL]. First: how are you?

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I looked at [PIECE OF WORK]. I want to show you what I saw, and hear what you think.

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The [TASK] was due on [DATE] and it came on [DATE]. I want to understand what happened.

## Opening for different mistakes

### A missed deadline

The [TASK] was due on [DATE]. I want to understand what made it hard to finish on time.

### An error in a document

I found [WHAT] on page [PAGE] of [DOCUMENT]. Can we go through it together?

### A mistake with a customer

I read the reply that went to [CUSTOMER]. I would like to hear how you saw it.

### A mistake that cost money

[WHAT HAPPENED] cost [AMOUNT OR TIME]. I want to understand it, not to blame. Walk me through it.

## **Responding and closing**

### **When they apologise**

Thank you for telling me. What matters now is [NEXT STEP]. What help do you need?

### **When they explain**

I understand. Let me check I have it right: [WHAT YOU HEARD]. Is that fair?

### **Agreeing a fix**

Let us agree what changes: you will [THEIR ACTION] by [DATE]. I will [YOUR ACTION] by [DATE].

### **Closing**

Thank you for talking this through. Let us check in on [DATE]. If anything formal needs to happen, I will speak to HR first and tell you.

<https://proskillpacks.github.io/managers/how-to-talk-to-an-employee-about-a-mistake/>

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